

If I do ... and If I did ...

A

Compare these examples:

- (1) LISA: Shall we go by bus or by train?
JESS: **If we go** by bus, it **will** be cheaper.

For Jess, it is possible that they will go by bus, so she says:

If we go by bus, it **will** be ...



- (2) Lisa and Jess decide to go by train.
Later, Jess talks to Joe.

JOE: How are you going to travel?

JESS: We're going by train. **If we went** by bus, it **would** be cheaper, but the train is quicker.

Now Jess knows they are not going to travel by bus, so she says:

If we went by bus, it **would** be ... (not **If we go** ...)



When we imagine something that will not happen, or we don't expect that it will happen, we use **if + past** (**if we went** / **if there was** / **if you found** etc.).

But the meaning is *not* past:

- ☐ What would you do **if you won** a lot of money? (we don't really expect this to happen)
- ☐ **If there was** (or **were**) an election tomorrow, who would you vote for?

For **if ... was/were**, see Unit 39C.

Compare **if I find** and **if I found**:

- ☐ I think I left my watch at your house. **If you find** it, can you call me?

but **If you found** a wallet in the street, what would you do with it?



B

We do not normally use **would** in the **if**-part of the sentence:

- ☐ I'd be very scared **if somebody pointed** a gun at me. (not **if somebody would point**)
- ☐ **If we went** by bus, it would be cheaper. (not **If we would go**)

But you can use **if ... would** when you ask somebody to do something:

- ☐ (from a formal letter) I would be grateful **if you would let** me know your decision as soon as possible.

C

In the other part of the sentence (not the **if**-part) we use **would** ('d) / **wouldn't**:

- ☐ What **would** you **do** if you were bitten by a snake?
- ☐ I'm not going to bed yet. I'm not tired. If I went to bed now, I **wouldn't sleep**.
- ☐ **Would** you **mind** if I used your phone?

Could and **might** are also possible:

- ☐ If I won a lot of money, I **might buy** a house. (= it is possible that I would buy a house)
- ☐ If it stopped raining, we **could go** out. (= we would be able to go out)

38.1 What do you say in these situations?

- 1 Of course you don't expect to win the lottery. Which do you say?
 - a If I win the lottery, I'll buy a big house. ☐
 - b If I won the lottery, I'd buy a big house. ☒ (b is correct)
- 2 You're not going to sell your car because it's old and not worth much. Which do you say?
 - a If I sell my car, I won't get much money for it. ☐
 - b If I sold my car, I wouldn't get much money for it. ☐
- 3 You often see Sarah. A friend of yours wants to contact her. Which do you say?
 - a If I see Sarah, I'll tell her to call you. ☐
 - b If I saw Sarah, I'd tell her to call you. ☐
- 4 You don't expect that there will be a fire in the building. Which do you say?
 - a What will you do if there is a fire in the building? ☐
 - b What would you do if there was a fire in the building? ☐
- 5 You've never lost your passport. You can only imagine it.
 - a I don't know what I'll do if I lose my passport. ☐
 - b I don't know what I'd do if I lost my passport. ☐
- 6 Somebody stops you and asks the way to a bank. Which do you say?
 - a If you go right at the end of this street, you'll see a bank on your left. ☐
 - b If you went right at the end of this street, you'd see a bank on your left. ☐
- 7 You're in a lift. There is an emergency button. Nobody is going to press it. Which do you say?
 - a What will happen if somebody presses that button? ☐
 - b What would happen if somebody pressed that button? ☐

38.2 Put the verb into correct form.

- 1 I'd be very scared if somebody pointed (point) a gun at me.
- 2 I can't afford to buy a car. If I (buy) a car, I'd have to borrow the money.
- 3 Don't lend Amy your car. If she (ask) me, I wouldn't lend her mine.
- 4 If the computer factory closed down, many people (lose) their jobs.
- 5 I don't think Gary and Emma will get married. I (be) amazed if they did.
- 6 What would you do if you (be) in a lift and it (stop) between floors?
- 7 If somebody (give) me £10,000, I (have) a very long holiday.

38.3 Write sentences beginning If ...

- 1 We've decided not to catch the 10.30 train. (arrive too early)
If we caught the 10.30 train, we'd arrive too early.
- 2 Kevin is not going to do his driving test now. (fail)
If he
- 3 We've decided not to stay at a hotel. (cost too much)
If
- 4 Sally isn't going to leave her job. (not / get another one)
- 5 We've decided not to invite Ben to the party. (have to invite his friends too)
- 6 I'm not going to tell him what happened. (not / believe me)

38.4 Use your own ideas to complete these sentences.

- 1 If I won a lot of money, I'd buy a house.
- 2 I'd be very angry if
- 3 If you bought a car,
- 4 I'd be surprised if
- 5 Would you mind if